

Fish armour?

MIT scientists have created designs for better armour, inspiration from which is derived from the shells of molluscs

New is hot

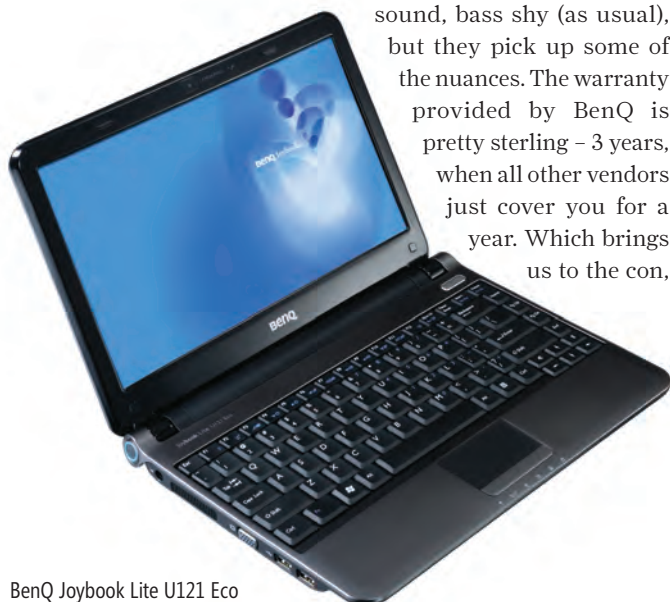
Valve reveals that 23 per cent of their customers are running Windows 7 and DX 11

minimal footprint and while docked the notebook manages a look of chic sophistication. The dock features all the connects of the notebook, including a VGA connect which will need to be used since the lid needs to be closed in order to use the dock. On the box Ubuntu 8.04 is mentioned, but we got ours with a clean copy of Windows XP. Do remember that the cost of an additional OS has to be considered. The 10.1-inch screen is pretty ordinary and at 1024 x 600 pixels, it's very basic. At Rs. 20,000 its at a sweet price point.

BenQ Joybook Lite U121 Eco

Not-so-small bundle of joy

A really nice looking netbook, this one has a smoky blue coloured lid that immediately attracts attention, especially since it's finished in glossy material. The display bezel is black, while the palm rest and the region surrounding the keypad is dark grey – very good colour combinations used – kudos to BenQ for getting the looks spot-on. The lid design is also funky with a circular rear



BenQ Joybook Lite U121 Eco

portion. The display bezel is narrow. The trackpad, while small, is reasonably accurate though the mouse buttons feel a little clicky. The keypad is slightly bigger than the U130, obviously, owing to the larger screen (11.6-inches), and this makes it much easier to use, even more than the ASUS' keypad, despite the fact that it had a larger screen. Key feedback is reasonably positive and feedback is firm, the keys are also well laid out. The last row of keys on the right has the Home/ page up / page down keys, typically placed as function-activated keys on the directional arrow keys – two currency symbols – representing the US dollar and Euro are also present, though we see little use for them.

The Z520 Atom CPU and 1 GB of DDR2 RAM mean its performance is no scorcher, on par with the ASUS 1201HA. From the design it's evident that the U121 Eco has been designed for a 6-cell battery as there's no protrusion of any sort. This battery is good for 4 hours and 17 minutes of video playback, which is very good. The speakers give out pleasant sound, bass shy (as usual), but they pick up some of the nuances. The warranty provided by BenQ is pretty sterling – 3 years, when all other vendors just cover you for a year. Which brings us to the con,

and there has to be one – its price. At Rs. 33,000 the Joybook Lite U121 Eco, will not be a joyful proposition to spend on, particularly since the likes of Acer's Timeline series are priced similarly and they have better hardware and will obviously perform better as well. Not recommended for the price tag, which is astronomical by netbook standards.

Acer 532H-2Bb

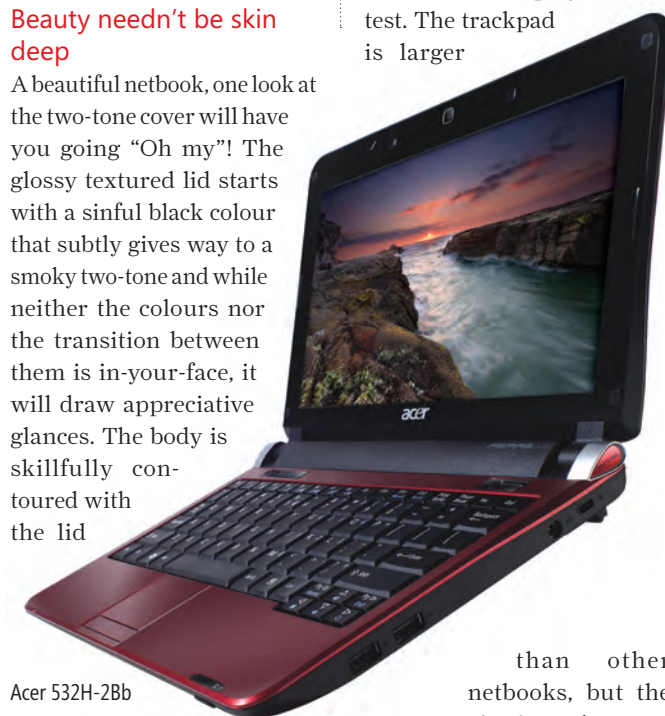
Beauty needn't be skin deep

A beautiful netbook, one look at the two-tone cover will have you going "Oh my"! The glossy textured lid starts with a sinful black colour that subtly gives way to a smoky two-tone and while neither the colours nor the transition between them is in-your-face, it will draw appreciative glances. The body is skillfully contoured with the lid

Acer 532H-2Bb

blending into the cut out of the body when closed. Build quality is very good – everything feels pretty solid. Even the activity and status LEDs exude quality. Opening it up, you're greeted by some of the largest keys we've seen on a netbook, and they're devoid of any beveling, which actually works pretty fine. Thanks to the greater surface area per key under your fingerpad, the keypad is a joy to use, despite the fact that it is cramped – a factor that cannot be helped given the tiny screen. Typing away even longer mails and

documents is actually something we got pretty accustomed to – something that didn't happen with any of the other netbooks. Initially the lack of beveling feels alien to the fingers, but after about an hour ones typing speed picks up. The display resolution is a paltry 1024 x 600, the de facto resolution for this size, but the display has marginally better colour rendition than some of the other displays in this test. The trackpad is larger



than other netbooks, but the texturing is a tad uncomfortable, although nowhere near as abrasive as the ASUS' trackpad. Tracking accuracy is good. The mouse button is a single long strip that works well, but feels clicky.

The Pinetrail N450 makes a second appearance here, after the U130. The battery is slightly lower rated as well, and the hard drive is smaller at 160 GB. Performance is good per se, and the 532H took the least time in the file-encoding test. Priced at Rs. 19,200 the 532H is definitely a worthy purchase for someone looking at something really compact and more